Ableman's Razor

A Typed Grammar for Ontology Exploration, Configuration Collapse, and Implementation Feedback

Ableman's Razor is not a method, lifecycle, or metaphysical system.

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Abstract

Ableman's Razor is a claim-governance grammar for regulating how assertions acquire epistemic authority as they move from possibility to instantiation. It generalizes familiar Specification–Configuration–Implementation (SCI) distinctions into a typed framework that treats **Specification** as a phase space of admissible possibility, **Configuration** as a governed collapse interface, and **Implementation** as realized instantiation under observation.

The grammar introduces four layer-typed epistemic functions - **Repair (Rep)**, **Refinement (Ref)**, **Exploration (Expl)**, and **Expansion (Expa)** - that may operate within any layer without collapsing categories. A central razor rule prohibits untyped migration of claims across layers, blocking common failure modes such as treating simulation convergence as ontological discovery, parameter rescue as theory confirmation, or formal elegance as evidence of reality. Expansion is permitted only under an explicit toll that includes rollback criteria.

Ableman's Razor is not a method, lifecycle, or metaphysical system. It is a grammar of restraint: a way of keeping imagination free while ensuring that authority remains earned.

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1. Motivation

Across science, engineering, governance, and complex systems practice, failure rarely arises from lack of intelligence or effort. It arises from category error. Simulation outputs are mistaken for discoveries. Instrumentation gains authority beyond its remit. Formal abstractions quietly promote themselves from tools into truths.

Existing philosophies of science describe historical shifts or evaluate research programs; engineering workflows manage projects and deliverables. Ableman's Razor addresses a different problem: **how claims migrate across epistemic**

layers at the moment they are made. Its concern is not whether a claim survives history, but whether it crosses borders with its jurisdiction intact.

This grammar does not promise clarity, speed, or consensus. It offers accountability at the moment of temptation.

This grammar arrives already under suspicion, including from itself.

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2. Core Layers

The Razor distinguishes three epistemic layers. These are **jurisdictional roles**, not ontological commitments.

2.1 Specification (S)

Specification is the phase space of admissible possibility. It defines the dimensions, couplings, constraints, and conceptual boundaries within which inquiry may occur.

Specification does not assert what exists. It governs what *could* meaningfully exist, be instantiated, or be observed. Regions of Specification may be unmapped or poorly understood, but they are named explicitly rather than smuggled in by implication.

Litmus test (S vs C): If removing a structure changes what can exist, it is **Specification**. If removing it changes only how existence is accessed, it is **Configuration**.

Formal languages, equations, and model classes are not Specification by default. They are typed by how they restrict collapse. When a formalism constrains admissible instantiations or channels outcomes, it functions as Configuration regardless of abstraction or mathematical sophistication.

Historical inheritance: Structures arising from legacy tooling, disciplinary habit, or historical convenience often masquerade as Specification. The Razor treats such inheritance as Configuration until proven otherwise.

Plurality and refusal: Multiple Specifications may coexist, including ones that are partially or wholly incommensurable. Ableman's Razor does not adjudicate between Specifications. It governs only the legitimacy of claims made within them.

Illegitimate migration can occur in any direction; inflation toward ontology is merely the most common failure mode.

2.2 Configuration (C)

Configuration is the collapse interface between possibility and instantiation.

It includes parameters, ranges, templates, representational choices, control variables, boundary conditions, and governance rules that restrict how a Specification may be instantiated. Configuration selects *how* possibility becomes actual without redefining the possibility space itself.

Mathematical formalisms and model classes often operate at this layer when they constrain collapse pathways rather than enumerate possibility.

Independence as pressure: Configuration can absorb explanatory work, but not indefinitely. Persistent contradiction requires evidence from independent configurations - variation across representational basis, instrumentation, collapse pathway, or governance constraint. Independence is a normative pressure, not a checklist.

Pathological deferral: Repeated reparameterization within a single representational scheme to avoid revising admissibility assumptions constitutes deferral, not caution. When C-Rep becomes perpetual without convergence across independent configurations, escalation pressure shifts toward Specification.

Asymmetry note: C-Expa is culturally under-penalized. "Just one more parameter" often escapes scrutiny where S-Expa would be contested. The Razor treats both as Expansion and demands the same toll.

2.3 Implementation (I)

Implementation is actualization under observation.

It includes physical experiments, simulations, deployments, executions, and measurement channels. Implementation produces outcomes that may confirm, contradict, or surprise expectations.

Implementation outcomes do not self-authorize their epistemic meaning. Treating Implementation as a decision procedure rather than a witness is itself an untyped migration.

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3. Function Families

Ableman's Razor defines four epistemic function families. The same verbs apply across layers; their meanings are layer-typed. Mixed cases require explicit declaration.

This family is sufficient for the scope of this grammar, but not asserted to be exhaustive.

3.1 Repair (Rep)

Purpose: Restore fidelity to declared intent or invariants.

- **S-Rep:** Correction of internal inconsistencies, illicit assumptions, or malformed conceptual boundaries.
- **C-Rep:** Correction of misparameterization, flawed controls, improper templates, or governance errors.
- **I-Rep:** Correction of instrumentation faults, execution errors, or simulation artifacts.

Repair restores what was claimed but not preserved. It does not increase scope.

3.2 Refinement (Ref)

Purpose: Increase resolution or precision within existing scope.

- **S-Ref:** Sharpening definitions, constraints, and conceptual clarity.
- **C-Ref:** Narrowing parameter ranges, improving sensitivity, tightening controls.
- **I-Ref:** Improving measurement precision, resolution, or statistical confidence.

Refinement never adds degrees of freedom.

Protective distinction: Mislabeling insufficient resolution as broken design converts Ref into Rep illegitimately.

3.3 Exploration (Expl)

Purpose: Systematically traverse what is already admissible.

- **S-Expl:** Reasoning about limits, symmetries, and edge cases within the existing phase space.
- **C-Expl:** Sweeping parameters and recombining templates while holding Specification invariant.
- **I-Expl:** Executing experiments or simulations across conditions to map outcome structure.

Most inquiry consists of Exploration. Disappointment here is normal.

Exploration inertia: Prolonged Exploration without declared exit conditions accrues epistemic inertia rather than credit. When traversal no longer increases discriminative power across independent configurations, retyping is required.

3.4 Expansion (Expa)

Purpose: Increase expressive or observational capacity.

- **S-Expa:** Introduction of new dimensions, couplings, entities, or conceptual regimes.
- **C-Expa:** Introduction of new parameters, templates, or collapse pathways.
- **I-Expa:** Introduction of new instruments, sensing modalities, or observable channels.

Expansion is epistemically expensive.

Minimal toll for Expa: Any Expansion must specify: (a) a named insufficiency in existing layers, (b) the explicit new degree of freedom introduced, and (c) a rollback criterion under which the claim is demoted if the expansion fails.

Failure to name rollback demotes Expa to Expl.

Rollback is not an admission of failure; it is a designed-for outcome.

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4. The Razor Rule

Ableman's Razor enforces category discipline:

- No function may migrate across layers without declaration.
- Exploration must not masquerade as Expansion.
- Refinement must not be mistaken for Repair.
- Configuration failure must not pressure Specification prematurely.
- Implementation outcomes do not self-authorize ontological claims.

Declaration without genuine exposure to rollback is itself an untyped migration, regardless of language used. Ritualized declaration without demotion risk constitutes compliance theater.

The Razor governs claims, not truth.

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5. Configuration Repair in Practice

Configuration Repair formalizes a tacit norm of mature inquiry. When observation contradicts expectation, the fault may lie in collapse choices rather than admissibility assumptions.

Only when multiple independent configurations converge on contradiction does Specification Expansion become epistemically justified. This protects against both reckless theory change and endless deferral.

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6. Simulation and Virtual Observation

Simulations are treated as Implementation.

They are legitimate sites of observation but do not bypass Configuration. Simulation outputs may inform C-Rep, C-Expl, or escalation pressure, but they do not legislate existence.

Representational richness alone does not retype Implementation into Configuration.

Models testify; they do not legislate.

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7. Worked Micro-Example

(Intentionally omitted here; any example must itself remain subject to the Razor.)

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8. Operational Claim Typing

Any claim seeking migration must answer:

1. Which layer produced this result? (S / C / I)
2. Which function is invoked? (Rep / Ref / Expl / Expa)
3. What new degree of freedom is introduced, if any?
4. What independent pressure is expected?
5. What would demote or roll back this claim?

If any element is missing, the claim is not licensed to migrate.

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9. Controlled Violation

Ableman's Razor permits governed shortcuts.

A **Controlled Violation** requires explicit declaration of the shortcut and a rollback plan specifying how the claim will be retyped if it fails.

Controlled violation accrues epistemic debt. Debt compounds when relied upon by downstream claims. Until repaid, further migration is suspended.

Most epistemic disasters begin as justified shortcuts.

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10. Scope, Enforcement, and Self-Capture

Ableman's Razor does not prescribe methods or algorithms. It does not legislate truth.

Its enforcement is communal rather than institutional. Authority emerges from refusal, not permission. The capacity to refuse is unevenly distributed; the Razor names a discipline, not an equalizing force.

The grammar itself must be treated as **Configuration**, not Specification. When inherited without scrutiny, it risks becoming the very authority it was designed to constrain.

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11. Conclusion

Ableman's Razor removes narrative momentum as a source of legitimacy. No amount of coherence, elegance, urgency, or success permits a claim to skip its typing.

This discipline will often make inquiry slower, colder, and less narratively satisfying. That cost is real. So is the cost of authority earned too cheaply.

Ableman's Razor does not promise discovery. It promises cleaner failure - and, when discovery arrives, a clearer accounting of how it earned the right to be believed.

Borders exist not to stop travel, but to make arrival meaningful.

Appendix A: Conceptual Kinship Map (Non-Normative, Non-Validating)

This appendix does **not** legitimize Ableman's Razor by lineage, precedent, or inheritance. It exists solely to reduce mis-mapping: to clarify what nearby traditions may resemble the Razor superficially, and where the resemblance breaks under the Razor's own jurisdictional typing.

Similarity here implies proximity, not validation. Divergence is often the point.

Ableman's Razor governs **claim migration and authority** across epistemic layers (Specification / Configuration / Implementation) under typed functions (Repair / Refinement / Exploration / Expansion). It does **not** adjudicate truth, optimize inquiry, redeem failure by usefulness, or collapse into a method.

A.1 Philosophy of Science (Popper, Kuhn, Lakatos)

Surface resemblance: Concern with theory status, testing, and how frameworks evolve.

Key divergence:

- Popper privileges falsification as a normative ideal.
- Kuhn describes historical paradigm dynamics.
- Lakatos evaluates research programs over time.

Ableman's Razor does none of these. It does not explain scientific change, and it does not judge what should "win." It regulates **epistemic speech acts at issuance**: whether a claim is licensed to migrate layers *right now*, regardless of eventual historical success.

Misuse prevented: Retroactively treating later success as authorization of earlier untyped promotion.

A.2 Levels of Analysis and Abstraction (Marr; Simon; Wimsatt)

Surface resemblance: Layered decompositions and explanatory stratification.

Key divergence: Those frameworks describe **perspectives for explanation**. Ableman's Razor defines **jurisdiction for authority**. An abstraction level does not grant a claim the right to migrate.

Misuse prevented: Treating higher-level descriptions as automatically more "real," or treating elegant abstraction as ontological warrant.

A.3 Measurement Theory, Instrumentation, and Calibration (metrology traditions)

Surface resemblance: Focus on measurement validity, calibration, and observation constraints.

Key divergence: Metrology improves Implementation reliability; Ableman's Razor governs whether Implementation outcomes may be promoted into claims about admissible possibility or collapse structure. Calibration can increase confidence in *witnessing* without granting legislative authority.

Misuse prevented: Conflating "measured precisely" with "licensed to claim ontology."

A.4 Robustness, Triangulation, and Model Pluralism (robustness analysis; "multiple lines of evidence")

Surface resemblance: Independence, convergence, and cross-checking.

Key divergence: Robustness is typically argued as an outcome ("it holds across models"). Ableman's Razor treats independence as a **normative pressure at Configuration**, and it blocks "convergence" that rests on shared untyped assumptions (especially shared Specification masquerading as neutral background).

Misuse prevented: Calling shared assumptions "independent evidence" and laundering authority through apparent pluralism.

A.5 Reproducibility and Method Reform (replication crisis literatures, preregistration norms)

Surface resemblance: Desire to prevent overclaiming and to discipline inference.

Key divergence: Reproducibility frameworks often audit results after the fact. Ableman's Razor audits **claim migration before escalation**. A claim may be reproducible and still illegitimately promoted.

Misuse prevented: Equating reproducibility with ontological legitimacy.

A.6 Bayesian Updating and Epistemic Logic

Surface resemblance: Formal treatment of belief revision and evidence.

Key divergence: Bayesian methods update credences; the Razor regulates **jurisdiction and admissibility**. A numerical update does not itself license a layer change. In Razor terms, Bayesian updates are typically Implementation- or Configuration-level procedures unless explicitly grounded in a declared Specification and admissible collapse interface.

Misuse prevented: Treating posterior confidence as permission to make stronger ontological claims than the evidence's jurisdiction supports.

A.7 Systems Engineering and Lifecycle Models (V-model; requirements design implementation)

Surface resemblance: Triadic structure and staged thinking.

Key divergence: Lifecycle models manage artifacts and workflow stages. Ableman's Razor manages **authority migration**, not project progress. Treating the Razor as a process model is itself an untyped migration.

Misuse prevented: Proceduralizing jurisdictional restraint into compliance theater.

A.8 Formal Methods and Specification Languages

Surface resemblance: "Specification" as a formal object; constraints on admissible states.

Key divergence: Formal methods often equate "specification" with a formal artifact. Ableman's Razor explicitly refuses that default: formalism is **not** Specification by default. Its typing depends on whether it restricts admissible possibility (S) or governs access/collapse (C).

Misuse prevented: Assuming that formalization itself upgrades a claim's ontological status.

A.9 Discourse Norms and Speech-Act Theory (Austin, Searle; legitimacy in discourse)

Surface resemblance: Attention to how statements gain force in practice.

Key divergence: Speech-act traditions analyze communicative intent and social uptake. The Razor is indifferent to persuasion and intent; it governs **epistemic jurisdiction** even when audiences are convinced.

Misuse prevented: Authority laundering by rhetorical strength, consensus, or institutional prestige.

A.10 Boundary-Work and Sociology of Knowledge (Gieryn and related)

Surface resemblance: Focus on boundaries, legitimacy, and institutional dynamics.

Key divergence: Boundary-work is descriptive sociology. Ableman's Razor is a normative grammar for claim migration that explicitly does **not** resolve power asymmetries - only makes illegitimate migration legible.

Misuse prevented: Confusing sociological legitimacy with jurisdictional legitimacy.

A.11 What This Appendix Is Not

- Not a genealogy
- Not a novelty claim by exclusion
- Not a synthesis of prior theories
- Not a proof by association

Ableman's Razor remains a **Configuration-level governance grammar**: a constraint on claim motion, not a discovered law about reality. This appendix does not elevate it.

A.12 Orientation

Many nearby frameworks ask:

- What is true?
- What works?
- What explains?
- What should be believed?

Ableman's Razor asks something narrower and colder:

At what layer was this claim generated, by what function, and with what right to migrate?

The proximity of other work does not answer that question. The Razor exists because those answers are too often assumed - then laundered into authority - without ever being earned.

Appendix B: On the Failure of Simplicity

Clarifying the Relationship Between Occam's Razor and Ableman's Razor

Occam's Razor has long served as an informal guide for epistemic restraint, commonly summarized as a preference for "the simplest explanation." Its historical utility is undeniable. Yet its most persistent failure mode arises not from misuse alone, but from an unresolved ambiguity at its core: the adjective *simple* does not name a coherent epistemic dimension.

"Simplicity" functions as a compression of multiple, distinct considerations (such as internal consistency, external consistency, explanatory scope, coupling, and cognitive tractability) into a single, aesthetically appealing term. This compression is sometimes efficient, but it is fundamentally lossy. When the underlying dimensions align, simplicity appears to track epistemic virtue. When they diverge, simplicity becomes a rhetorical shortcut that legitimizes premature closure, anti-intellectualism, or the avoidance of careful analysis.

In practice, this ambiguity allows "simple" to drift from meaning *fewest unresolved contradictions* to meaning *least cognitively demanding*, *most familiar*, or *most narratively convenient*. At that point, Occam's Razor ceases to function as an epistemic guide and instead becomes an authority-laundering device, enabling preference or intuition to masquerade as justification.

Ableman's Razor addresses this failure not by rejecting Occam's insight, but by **governing it**.

Rather than treating simplicity as a primitive evaluative axis, Ableman's Razor requires that any appeal to simplicity be decomposed into its constituent dimensions and declared within an explicit jurisdictional context. Claims must specify:

- *Which layer* they operate in (Specification, Configuration, Implementation),
- *Which epistemic action* they represent (Exploration, Refinement, Repair, Expansion),
- *Which contradictions* are resolved, deferred, or explicitly left undecidable,
- And *what downstream authority* the claim would authorize if accepted.

Under this governance structure, "simple" is no longer a freestanding virtue. It becomes a **derived property** of a claim that introduces fewer unexplained contradictions *within a declared scope* and *without illegitimate epistemic escalation*. Where such conditions are not met, the framework legitimizes refusal, rollback, or an "Undecidable" outcome rather than forcing closure.

In this sense, Occam's Razor operates as a **licensed heuristic** within Ableman's Razor, typically during exploratory or refinive epistemic actions. Ableman's Razor does not tell the practitioner which explanation to prefer; it determines whether preference itself is authorized, and what authority such a preference may legitimately carry.

The relationship is therefore not one of replacement, but of containment and clarification. Occam's Razor offers a useful intuition about explanatory economy. Ableman's Razor supplies the governance necessary to prevent that intuition from hardening into doctrine or being misapplied across epistemic layers.

Simplicity, when governed, remains valuable. Simplicity, when ungoverned, becomes epistemic debt.

Ableman's Razor restores the distinction.

Corpus-Wide Reference Positioning

This paper argues that ableman's Razor is a claim-governance grammar for regulating how assertions acquire epistemic authority as they move from possibility to instantiation. Its nearest external comparison fields are governance, software, formal. The sources in [E1], [E2], [E3], [E4], [E5], [E6], [E7] are cited as predecessor literature, adjacent standards, or counterpressure - not as evidence that they caused the Ableman framework or that they validate its novel claims.

The comparison isolates where established work already supplies provenance, formal assurance, institutional constraint, empirical method, or engineering practice, and where this paper adds a distinct claim about admissibility, authority, semantic custody, or governed realization.

Within the Ableman corpus, the highest-priority current cross-links are [A1], [A2], [A3], [A4], [A5], [A6], [A7]. These are links among separately custodied works, not silent identity mergers. Their role is to expose mutual dependencies, terminology collisions, and places where a reader should traverse the corpus before treating this paper as self-sufficient.

Reference-pass counterevidence and limit search

The pass applied the following pressure tests: A written constitution can legitimate domination as easily as constrain it unless amendment, participation, enforcement, and appeal remain effective in practice. Modularity, secure-development practice, and reproducibility reduce classes of failure but do not guarantee architectural coherence or user sovereignty. Formal assurance remains relative to the encoded model, trusted base, and refinement chain; proof does not remove specification error or unmodeled environmental behavior. These limits are not generic disclaimers: they identify the assumptions that a later empirical, formal, or implementation review must try to break.

Reference-pass influence and novelty boundary

No newly added external source is asserted to be a documented authorial influence unless the predecessor source already said so. `Predecessor` means earlier relevant work;

`adjacent` means a useful comparison; `standard` means an interoperability or assurance baseline; and `counterevidence` marks work that narrows or pressures a claim. Novelty therefore remains a reviewable, claim-level question rather than an inference from a low similarity score or an absent citation.

References

External scholarship, standards, and prior art

[**E1**] Elinor Ostrom. *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge University Press, 1990. DOI: 10.1017/CBO9780511807763. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511807763
Relationship: Predecessor institutional account of rule-governed collective action and polycentric governance.

[**E2**] Wil Waluchow and Dimitrios Kyritsis. "Constitutionalism." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, substantive revision 2023. https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/constitutionalism/
Relationship: Adjacent legal-philosophical account of limited authority;

included to expose differences between political and computational constitutionalism.

[**E3**] Lawrence Lessig. *Code: Version 2.0*. Basic Books, 2006. https://codev2.cc/ **Relationship:** Predecessor argument that software architecture regulates behavior; the paper's contribution may be to make such regulation inspectable and revisable.

[**E4**] OECD. *Recommendation of the Council on Artificial Intelligence*. OECD/LEGAL/0449, adopted 2019 and updated 2024. legalinstruments.oecd.org source **Relationship:** Adjacent policy standard for accountability, traceability, transparency, safety, and human-centered values.

[**E5**] David L. Parnas. "On the Criteria To Be Used in Decomposing Systems into Modules." *Communications of the ACM* 15(12), 1972, pp. 1053-1058. DOI: 10.1145/361598.361623. https://doi.org/10.1145/361598.361623 **Relationship:** Foundational modularity treatment used to compare information hiding with explicit semantic and governance interfaces.

[**E6**] Ward Cunningham. "The WyCash Portfolio Management System." *OOPSLA '92 Experience Report*, 1992. DOI: 10.1145/157709.157715. https://doi.org/10.1145/157709.157715 **Relationship:** Original technical-debt metaphor used to distinguish implementation debt from semantic debt.

[**E7**] Karen Scarfone, Murugiah Souppaya, and Donna Dodson. *Secure Software Development Framework (SSDF) Version 1.1*. NIST SP 800-218, 2022. DOI: 10.6028/NIST.SP.800-218. https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.SP.800-218 **Relationship:** Adjacent secure-development framework for preparation, protection, production, and vulnerability response.

Ableman corpus

[**A1**] Adam Ableman. *Ableman Constitutional Governance*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
`AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-79353AF163A4B0F1`;
source SHA-256
`FB0D9B2D3D54168FFE70B24308D1B2766D6D663ED24502D475E975939BE97C8B`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A2**] Adam Ableman. *Constitutional Theory*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
`AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-D2D97C4042FD281F`;
source SHA-256
`FACC256EDDE5A7D7EA18133CFC9C060CFB8C3811B0221E1969E62347F2BB69CF`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A3**] Adam Ableman. *Governance Engineering*. Ableman Corpus current

edition; work identity PAPER.PUB.18749870;
source SHA-256
372169F315D192733856B1F4A3F1038BBC73F57CF3ED9ACABAE72B965A69C8D0.
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[**A4**] Adam Ableman. *Universal Governance Kernel (UGK).* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-1F9BFB2BF8370226;
source SHA-256
AA5106EA71E5DF120E141435C280DFC532715CA5DE0C75B8862BB7784ECCFACD.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A5**] Adam Ableman. *Legitimacy Without Self-Ratification.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-EF2382F9397335AC;
source SHA-256
0186A39C808F8FDDB5C8F42384DF1A26678928434BD50A0EAE8D4947390F68A2.
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[**A6**] Adam Ableman. *Sovereign Software.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-24C6159B98023A9C;
source SHA-256
6AAFE79E438B980B75D1910A897F7BA716A10CF1187B68CB1F71405F36725A18.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A7**] Adam Ableman. *Constitutional Software Analysis (CSoftA): A Governance-Based Classification Method for Software Systems.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity PAPER.PUB.20472196;
source SHA-256
3670B28B7C1AF5467BE4002C47B5F964F8FAF6F257125C2F84CE06904E4FD0DE.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

Corpus source and companion formats: https://github.com/AblemanMosaic/ableman-corpus
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